

Why did you pick this idea to work on? Do you have domain expertise in this area? How do you know people need what you're making?

At 18, I was homeless, and a fugitive. I worked as a server to afford a lawyer and a library card so I could use public computers to email documents to my lawyer and to the schools I was applying to in the U.S. as an international student. My lawyer was affordable, but overwhelmed. Common App didn't accept my legal documents. Computer time was money, and every delay felt dangerous because my life depended on it.

Later, I received full-ride scholarships to MIT and Columbia, and we all tried to coordinate my arrival to the U.S. It took weeks of back and forth across my lawyer's crowded inbox and university offices. Urgent questions always seemed to come at 2 a.m., and the only person who fully knew my case often could not respond quickly in the sea of documents/questions they received.

As a researcher at the Columbia AI Lab and a software engineering intern at Amazon and Meta, I watched immigration coordination break down around CPT and OPT windows, I-9 onboarding, SSN applications, etc.

Counsel was often consulted late because it's costly and not timely to consult them for every single employee or applicant a company extends an offer to.

Today, the system lives in email threads, PDFs, calendar reminders, and overloaded inboxes.

That is what led me to Ellis: an AI agent that answers questions and provides a shared case repository where the employee, HR, and immigration counsel can manage a case together. It stores documents, extracts key facts like expirations and filing windows, creates a task list with clear owners and reminders, turns long notices into what changed and what to do next, exports clean bundles counsel can review quickly, and submits documentation directly to USCIS.

I know people need this because I needed it at every stage, and so did the organizations trying to help me. Universities, nonprofits, and companies all face the same bottleneck: high stakes processes managed through ad hoc workflows. Too often, employers reduce the whole process to a single checkbox, "Will you need sponsorship?" because the burden feels too high. Ellis lowers that burden. It saves time by automating most of the process, answers questions, reduces counsel costs by preparing counsel ready packets only when needed, and gives every case a clear shared workflow that teams can follow with confidence.

Who are your competitors? What do you understand about your business that they don't?

Our competitors are traditional corporate immigration firms like Fragomen, BAL, Ogletree, and Berry Appleman; newer immigration companies like Mayflower, Boundless, Gale, Casium, Plymouth, Alma, and Manifest; and broader HR/payroll platforms like Deel, Rippling, and Remote.

The law firms are expensive, slow, and service-heavy. The newer companies are better, but most are still built around the same unit of work: a case, a petition, or an attorney-led workflow. HR platforms treat immigration as a feature inside payroll or EOR, not as the core product.

What we understand is that immigration is not one form or one filing. It's a recurring operational system for every immigrant: deadlines, documents, dependents, work authorization, manager changes, role changes, travel, renewals, RFEs, payroll updates, and counsel handoffs. Today this runs across Slack, email, Dropbox, HRIS, spreadsheets, and law firm portals. The immigrant experiences the pain first, but the employer pays the price.

Our bet is that the winner in immigration will not be the firm with the most attorneys or the HR platform with a visa feature. It will be the AI Agent that assists during immigrant life-cycle operations. We can be 30–50% cheaper and faster than traditional firms because we use AI and workflow automation to make each attorney and paralegal handle far more cases, while giving employees and employers a faster and cheaper process.

How do or will you make money? How much could you make?

Subscriptions

If you had any other ideas you considered applying with, please list them. One may be something we've been waiting for. Often when we fund people it's to do something they list here and not in the main application.

Yo should i answer this?

What convinced you to apply to Y Combinator? Did someone encourage you to apply? Have you been to any YC events?

I applied to Y Combinator because I want to build Ellis with the urgency of someone who has lived the stakes. This is personal, and I'm deeply passionate about fixing it. I was encouraged to apply by mentors and friends who know my story. I haven't been to YC events yet.

How did you hear about Y Combinator?

Most of the services I use everyday were once a YC startup.

What is your company going to make? Please describe your product and what it does or will do

Ellis is an AI agent that companies/non-profits/law firms pay so their immigrant employees/asylum cases/immigration cases so they can both manage immigration tasks in one place in coordination, while HR and/or immigration counsel stay aligned.

What it ships: A shared case workspace/repository plus an agent that:

stores documents and extracts key information (expiration dates, filing windows, dependents)

creates a task list with owners (employee vs HR vs counsel) and reminders

turns long notices into what changed and what to do next, with citations to public guidance when possible

exports a clean bundle between counsel/HR/employers (forms completed with the employee's/immigrant's/employer's facts, plus evidence inventory), creating a productive feedback loop towards progress